



Batting fulcrum: Virat Kohli's improving batting average against spin makes his experience a crucial asset in the middle-order, particularly against formidable spinners like Mehidy Hasan Miraz and Shakib Al Hasan. VIJAY SONEJI

the Test series Down Under looming large and his heroics at the Gabba in 2021-22 still the flavour of the storied rivalry.

Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill were India's top run-scorers against England this year, amassing 712 and 452 runs, respectively, and the youth brigade could lead the charge against the spinners. Meanwhile, Rohit's average against the tweekers has been more than 50 for the first time since 2019, and he will hope to continue setting the tone at the top.

If that goes pear-shaped, the lower-order spin-bowling all-rounders will be expected to lead the rescue act, as has been the case of late in home Tests.

Ravindra Jadeja (41.20) and Axar Patel (39.60) boast of the third and

fourth-highest batting averages at home in Tests since 2021, respectively, amongst batters who have played at least 10 innings. With Ashwin and Kuldeep Yadav also in the mix, India's spin selection could hinge on the prevalent batting conditions. However, overlooking the role of the pacers in Tests in India would be anachronistic, especially with a certain Jasprit Bumrah in the ranks. The fast-bowling enigma had 19 scalps in the England series, was joint-second in the wickets' charts, and topped all the bowling averages with an astounding 16.89.

He will be supported by Mohammed Siraj, who is finding his stride in the longest format, as Mohammad Shami continues to be sidelined due to injury. Akash Deep is one of the five players who debuted in the England series and one of the three to be retained — alongside Sarfaraz and Jurel. Akash impressed with a three-for on debut in Ranchi and is coming off a nine-wicket haul in the Duleep Trophy. Perhaps the only surprise call-up was Yash Dayal, who has come a long way since being

an unwanted appendage to Rinku Singh's final-over six-hitting spree in the Indian Premier League.

The left-arm pacer is being groomed for a potential role in the Border-Gavaskar Trophy and has been on the selectors' radar since IPL 2024, where he was Royal Challengers Bengaluru's highest wicket-taker and a key member of the franchise's miraculous mid-season turnaround.

Though he has a limited First-Class experience of 24 matches, he picked up three crucial wickets in India B's win over India A in the first round of the Duleep Trophy.

With Rohit (37), Kohli (35), Jadeja (35) and Ashwin (37) not getting any younger, workhorses Cheteshwar Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane axed for the foreseeable future, and Bumrah's fitness and all-format availability a priority for the management, a 10-Test season will be the ideal breeding ground for identifying the next core group, developing effective pace reserves, and perhaps even setting in motion a smooth succession plan.